

Consent Form

School of Computing and Information Systems

Technology Innovation Project



Student Researchers: Anita Yang, Tammy Lee, Bella Chen, Leo Lin

Name of Participant:

Charles

1. I consent to participate in this project, the details of which have been explained to me, and I have been provided with a written plain language statement to keep.
2. I understand that the purpose of this research is to investigate how individuals seek and provide local help within their communities, and to evaluate the potential of a digital platform to improve accessibility, trust, and efficiency in connecting people with local support services.
3. I understand that my participation in this project is for research purposes only.
4. I acknowledge that the possible effects of participating in this research project have been explained to my satisfaction.
5. In this project I will be required to participate in a short interview or survey about my experiences with seeking or offering local help, and I may be asked to provide feedback on a prototype or concept of a digital platform.
6. I understand that my interviews may be audio recorded.
7. I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I am free to withdraw from this project anytime without explanation or prejudice and to withdraw any unprocessed data that I have provided.
8. I have been informed that the confidentiality of the information I provide will be safeguarded subject to any legal requirements; my data will be password protected and accessible only by the named researchers.
9. I understand that given the small number of participants involved in the study, it may not be possible to guarantee my anonymity.
10. I understand that after I sign and return this consent form, it will be retained by the student researchers.

Participant Signature:

Charles

Date:

31/03/2026

HelpMate

Semi-Structured Interview Guide

INFO90010 Technology Innovation Project | Group B

How to use this guide

Q Core question Ask every interviewee. Do not skip.

↳ Probe / follow-up Use when the interviewee touches on that theme. Not compulsory.

↪ Conditional branch Only ask if a specific situation or keyword is mentioned.

💡 Interviewer tip Reminders on technique — not read aloud.

Interviewee:	Charles Huang	Date:	31/03/2026
Interviewer:	Yang-Chun Lin	Location:	Iglu Melbourne Central

Opening Script (read aloud)

"Hi, thank you for meeting with us. We are postgraduate students from the University of Melbourne working on HelpMate — a hyper-local platform that helps people exchange small everyday tasks and resources with others nearby. Before we start, please read the Plain Language Statement. Any questions? [Pause] Great. May I also record our conversation for note-taking purposes? [Wait for consent signature.] Let's begin."

Section 1 — Background (3–4 min)

Q1

Can you tell me a bit about yourself — what you are studying or doing, how long you have lived in your current area, and what your living situation is like (relationship between you and your neighbors)?

Response notes:

Master of IS

Been living in an apartment in the CBD for 4 months. And he doesn't really know his neighborhood.

Q2

How well do you know your neighbours or the people around you?

↳ If they say they barely know them:

"Has there ever been a moment where you wished you knew them a bit better? What was the situation?"

↪ If they say they know neighbours well:

"How did that come about — was there a particular moment or event that helped you connect?"

He doesn't really know people within this building, but does know someone living nearby.

He didn't want to actively meet up with other people living in this apartment

Section 2 — Current Behaviours (5–7 min)

 **Interviewer tip:** Ground questions in real past events, not hypotheticals. If they start speaking generally, redirect: "Can you walk me through a specific time that happened?"

Q3

Think about the last time you needed help with something small — like borrowing a tool, getting a ride, or carrying something heavy. What did you do, and why did you choose that approach?

 **Consequence probe:**

"And how did that turn out? Did it solve the problem, or did it leave you feeling frustrated?"

 **If they ended up buying something they only needed once:**

"Looking back, do you feel like that was the best solution? What would have been ideal?"

 **If they mention feeling awkward or hesitant to ask:**

"That's totally ok — can you tell me a bit more about why it felt uncomfortable? Was it about the person, or more of a general feeling?"

Response notes:

He doesn't really seek for help because he doesn't trust someone to do the task, or he can just spend some necessary money to achieve the tasks

It doesn't feel like a one-time waste because he does believe that there may be some certain cases where he will use that thing again

Q4

Have you ever been in a situation where you needed help but genuinely did not know who to turn to, or felt too uncomfortable to ask? Can you walk me through that?

 **Emotional probe:**

"How did that make you feel at the time? Did you manage to resolve it eventually?"

 **Frequency probe:**

"Does that kind of situation come up often for you, or was it more of a one-off?"

 **If they mention being new to the area or being an international student:**

"It sounds like the lack of a local network made this harder. Is that something you would say affects you regularly?"

Response notes:

So far no. He feels a bit uncomfortable asking and seeking for helps from other people (personality)

Q5

Have you ever helped someone nearby — a neighbour, classmate, or even a stranger? What was that like, and what motivated you to help?

↳ Extending probe:

"Would you do it again? Is there anything that would make you more or less likely to help someone in a similar situation?"

↗ If they say they have never helped anyone nearby:

"Has there been a moment where you considered helping but decided not to? What held you back?"

Response notes:

He tends to help others if he sees someone needs help.

He helped his classmate because she wanted to borrow a screwdriver. He will help her again because he trusts her and she returned the stuff in a good condition

Section 3 — Challenges & Pain Points (4–5 min)

Q6

When you try to find help — through apps, social media, or friends — what is the most frustrating part of that process?

↳ If they mention slow or unreliable responses:

"How long would you be willing to wait before you gave up and tried something else?"

↳ If they mention trust or safety concerns:

"Can you describe what a trustworthy source of help would look like to you?"

↗ If they say they do not use any apps or platforms for this:

"That's really useful to know — what is your go-to approach then? And has it ever let you down?"

Response notes:

Rejection from the people he asks.

Hard to say how long will he wait because it's case by case

Q7

Have you ever used a platform like Facebook groups, WhatsApp groups, or Nextdoor to ask for or offer help? What worked, and what did not?

↳ If they had a bad experience:

"What specifically went wrong? Was it something about the platform itself, or the people involved?"

⚡ **If they say they have never tried any platform:**

"What has stopped you from trying? Is it more about awareness, trust, or something else?"

Response notes:

Never, he doesn't trust digital platforms when it comes to looking for helps. Trust is the biggest issues (without knowing who's on the other side of screen)

Section 4 — Reaction to the Platform Idea (5 min)

💡 **Interviewer tip:** Read this brief platform description aloud before Q8: "Our platform lets you post small help requests on a map — like borrowing a tool or asking for help moving boxes — and people nearby can respond. There is also a reputation and reward system to build trust between users."

Q8

What is your first reaction to this idea? Can you imagine a situation in your own life where you would actually use something like this?

↳ **If they give a positive reaction:**

"What is the thing that appeals to you most about it?"

↳ **If they seem sceptical or lukewarm:**

"That's fair — what would need to change about it for it to feel genuinely useful or appealing to you?"

⚡ **If they immediately describe a specific use case:**

"That is a great example. Walk me through what that interaction would look like — what would you post, and what would you hope to happen next?"

Response notes:

It's an innovative and creative idea because he hasn't seen any similar service before. He thinks this platform is good for people who are moving alone to build their relationship with their neighbours (the platform can reduce physical distance)

Q9

What would make you hesitant to use this platform, or stop using it after trying it once?

↳ **Solution probe:**

"What would need to be true for those concerns to go away?"

⚡ **If they raise safety or stranger-danger concerns:**

"What features or signals would make you feel safe enough to interact with someone you had never met before?"

Response notes:

Safety issues and trustworthiness of this platform: he doesn't know the people or other users on this platform. He says that he values people's politeness and respect. These two things are the most

important signals to him meaning that he can start interacting with this person. Moreover, returning process is another concern to him (how to ensure the item is still in a good condition)

Section 5 — Trust, Safety & Incentives (4–5 min)

Q10

What would make you trust someone enough to accept help from them, or offer to help them, through this platform?

↳ If they mention a rating or profile system:

"How many reviews or interactions do you think someone would need before you felt comfortable trusting them?"

↗ If they are sceptical that any online signal could build enough trust:

"Is there anything in real life — outside of an app — that gives you that kind of trust in a stranger? Could something like that be replicated digitally?"

Response notes:

Comments or human-generated reviews are more important than ratings. So, other users' feedback matters to him.

Q11

If there were a points or reputation system where you earned recognition for helping — would that motivate you, or would it feel artificial? Why?

↳ If they say it would motivate them:

"What kind of reward or recognition would feel meaningful to you — badges, a visible score, real-world benefits, or something else?"

Response notes:

He personally feels that it's not attractive to him. Getting the title of the best helper cannot benefit him in real life. He prefers to have real-world prize, like coupons or similar certificate like LinkedIn

Section 6 — Feature Priorities (2–3 min)

Q12

If this platform launched tomorrow with only two or three features, what would be the most important ones to you, and why?

↳ If they suggest a feature you had not considered:

"That is interesting — can you tell me more about why that matters to you specifically?"

Response notes:

1. Identity verification
2. Trustworthy credit score

Closing Script (read aloud)

"Is there anything else about this kind of platform — or your own experiences getting or giving help — that you think we should know? [Pause] Thank you so much for your time. Your responses will be kept confidential and referred to by a pseudonym in any reporting. You are welcome to withdraw at any time."

Additional Observations

Use this space for body language, emotional cues, unexpected themes, or follow-up items for analysis: